Government were in these matters advisers to the Home Government, and that in the last resort it rested with the latter to decide'.

Balfour, however, quickly poured cold water on Curzon's implications that London should proceed without listening to Delhi.[118] For Chelmsford believed that open revolution would ensue there should the emir ally himself with Britain against Turkey. Habibullah was already facing intense pressure from his subjects to provide support to Muslim Turkey, and was only just managing to maintain his country's neutrality by arguing that Afghanistan would be ruined by entering the war.[119] Trying to get Afghanistan to support the British cause was therefore simply unfeasible. Luckily, on this point Chelmsford had Montagu's support, who argued in the next Eastern Committee meeting that, 'as the Indian Government had hitherto been successful throughout the war in their dealings with the Amir, he thought the Committee should trust their judgement in the present case'.[120]

As already noted, one particularly important reason the Indian government was so reluctant to become overly involved in Persia was the problems it was facing in Afghanistan. The murder of the emir Habibullah had proved a great blow to Britain, not least because of the unrest it created in Afghanistan. Habibullah's willingness to stay loyal to Britain despite strong pressure from his people to support Turkey, was invaluable to Britain, although it may have actually cost the emir his life.[121] Whatever the cause of it, Habibullah's death set off a chain of events that would culminate in the Third Anglo-Afghan War. While Habibullah's brother, Nasrullah Khan, immediately announced himself the new emir, this was contested by Amanullah, Habibullah's third son. By 4 March, Nasrullah had given up his claim and Amanullah had been proclaimed emir.[122]

*Unfortunately for Britain, Amanullah was well known for his nationalistic, anti-British tendencies, and from the outset of his reign the new emir seemed determined to be antagonistic towards his imperial neighbour.[123] Traditionally Britain's relationship with the ruler of Afghanistan was one of 'gentle bondage' – the emir was expected to be a complaisant liege and in exchange he received a generous subsidy.[124] While many of Amanullah's predecessors had grumbled about this arrangement, he was the first emir to*